

Collage and the History of Treaty Negotiations over 500 years,
Aboriginal and Treaty Rights, 2004

A large, dense collage of various materials including newspaper clippings, photographs, maps, and text labels like 'Freedom', 'Trust', 'Land', 'WAR', and 'harmony'. The collage is a complex assembly of cut-out images and text, featuring a central map of Canada, a cartoon character, and various headlines such as 'BACK TO THE LAND', 'OUR LAND IS OUR FUTURE', 'CATASTROPHI AT JAMES BAY', and 'LET'S TALK SENSELY'. The overall theme appears to be related to land rights, social issues, and environmental concerns.









History of Collage

The art of collage began in 1912 when Picasso pasted a section of commercially printed oilcloth to his cubist painting, *Still Life with Chair Caning* ¹. Since then, it has become a form of basic Dada and surrealist art that has been used in various political movements throughout the 20th century as a means of expressing discontent and as a tool for destabilizing the status quo. Indeed, in discussing the collage, Picasso clearly defined its purpose: "No, painting is not made to decorate apartments. [t's an offensive and defensive weapon against the enemy."²

The revolutionary quality at the heart of collage stems from the unorthodox and often subversive way in which images are combined. The unusual combination of images and material raises questions about the nature of existing reality and the possibility of new realities as created by the artist. As Katherine Hoffman has suggested , "Collage may be seen as a quintessential twentieth-century art form with multiple layers and signposts pointing to a variety of forms and realities , and to the possibility or suggestion of countless new realities."³ Artists use the juxtaposed images in collage to reflect the changing realities around them.

¹ Museum of Modern Art, New York City

² Understanding Collage, [http://www.collagetown.com/ history 01.shtm1](http://www.collagetown.com/history%201.htm)

³ Katherine Hoffman, *Collage: Critical Views* (Ann Arbor, MI: UMI Research Press, 1989), *online*: [http://www.zimmerli.museum .rutgers .edu/col lections/summ/br ie f%20history. html](http://www.zimmerli.museum.rutgers.edu/collections/summ/br ie f%20history. html)

The collage became popular with the situationalist movement in the late 1950s as a means of revolt against the "picturesque and sublime" ⁴ paintings which depicted pastoral scenes of people at ease in an idyllic landscape. These paintings gave the impression of the city as "an ideal urban landscape where the struggle with nature, with the body, with space and with class had inexplicably come to an end"⁵. By contrast, the collage portrayed the city as a place where the struggles remained severe and often incoherent.

Collage and the history of treaty negotiations in Canada

The idea of collage as a means to alter a preconceived reality and suggest alternate realities is what makes it so useful in tracking the portrayal of the evolution of treaty negotiations in North America over the last 500 years . By including images , maps, articles, newspaper clippings and some objects, I have attempted to create a feeling of incoherence that to me is characteristic of the progression of treaties from the time of contact to the present day.

The use of the words evolution and progression themselves do not accurately reflect the nature of the treaty process. There is generally a positive connotation ascribed to concepts like evolve and progress; however, history tells a different story when the earliest treaties, such as the Treaty of Lancaster in 1744, where both Aboriginal and non-Aboriginal parties were treated with equal diplomacy and respect, are compared with the later numbered treaties and some of the early modern agreements where the same respect and courtesy were

not extended to the Aboriginal parties.

Widespread use of words like evolution and progression in describing historical events is illustrative of how the printed version of history is often narrow and misleading. By displaying certain images and excerpts from various treaty-making events of the last 500 years in fragments and layers, I hope to give the viewer the opportunity to develop new perspectives and realities about treaty-making and its goals and outcomes.

While the goal of the collage is to stimulate the development of new realities, there remain 3 underlying themes that I endeavour to represent: one, the relationship between Aboriginal title and treaty-making; two, the dual nature of the notion of Aboriginal title (i.e. property and jurisdiction or self government); and three, the relationship between litigation , judicial decisions and politics.

The relationship between Aboriginal title and treaty-making is illustrated through the images of land and resource use. Aboriginal title as the basis for treaty-making is a dominant thread throughout the history of treaty-making. Contemporary analysis of the existence or likelihood of title relies heavily on land and resource use by a particular nation for proof of title. The dual nature of Aboriginal title is shown through the present day agreements such as the Nisga'a Final Agreement and the Tlicho Agreement, where self government and defined boundaries are paramount features. There are other agreements as well that are illustrative of the two aspects; however, due to space constraints, I have included only a few examples.

⁴ Simon Sadler, *The Situationalist City*, MIT Press (1998) at 77.

⁵ Ibid

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The relationship between litigation, judicial decisions and politics is also a central theme running through the centuries of treaty-making. It appears in different ways in different times in history. It is clear from Andrew Jackson's blatant disregard for the Marshall J's decision in Worcester v. Georgia that politics played a key role in the actual shape of treaty-making, regardless of what the law required. The pre-eminence of politics is also apparent in the present day treaty process. The idea of the need for certainty to encourage investment and stimulate economic activity in order for political parties to maintain popular support has influenced much of the treaty-making in British Columbia to date. This manifested in B.C. as provincial government denial of the existence of Aboriginal title in many cases. Though there have been some recent exceptions such as the Nisga'a Final Agreement and some recent agreements in principle (AIPs). As discussed in class, there are additional problems with the AIPs, such as the government's unwillingness to discuss key self governance issues, that seem to suggest that the treaty process is still being undermined.

In addition, despite the recent achievement of some agreements, the treaty process in B.C. is often painfully slow. At the same, the courts at all levels, from provincial to the

Supreme Court of Canada have expressed their preference for clear legislative solutions to present-day issues rather than relying on the courts to make the tough decisions.

Structure of the Collage

The base is the 2004 Randall map of Canada. Other than Nunavut, there is no adequate representation of First Nations interests reflected in the boundaries in this map. This map does include any land that is currently claimed but as yet unproven. It portrays Canada from a single perspective that reflects only the mainstream socio-political reality. It is depicted with boldly defined boundaries containing soothing, aesthetically pleasing colours that are suggestive of the "ideal urban landscape" where the struggles with nature and among peoples had been resolved. This representation of Canada is inaccurate and incomplete .

Thus, I have attempted to portray some of the missing elements in the collage . While I have loosely kept to some of the geographic areas where different incidents occurred, the way the images are set up is intended to portray incoherence and falsity in the Canadian interpretation of history. Additionally, the images are fragmented and layered to represent the equally fragmented and layered nature of history. By juxtaposing material and images from different cultures and often different centuries, I have tried to show that there are several different ways in which history can be interpreted and each can yield different realities. For example, I have included two opposing advertisements in the New York Times with respect to the Hydro-Quebec hydro-electricity project on the La

Grande River. The advertisement opposing the project ran the week before the Hydro-Quebec ad defending the project.

Juxtaposing layered and fragmented images also makes it difficult to form a simple reality. In one glance, the various materials can appear overwhelmingly chaotic. This is in direct opposition to the traditional map that lies underneath, which lays out the boundaries in a static, seemingly settled manner. The chaotic nature of the collage is a deliberate deviation from the character of the map and is intended to illustrate that for a deeper understanding of history, and ultimately of the present day conditions, it is necessary to look beyond the accepted status quo. Only by scrutinizing the information we are presented with and digging deeper than the surface, will we begin to understand the true history and effects of treaty-making in North America. The images in the collage often extend beyond the map underneath. Again, this is deliberate and is designed to show that history cannot be easily contained and does not fit into a neat box.

Despite my attempt to structure the collage in a way that would yield new realities to different viewers, there is no escaping the bias I have brought to it. My own culture, background and experience influenced what I chose what to include and how it was put together. For example, it is quite apparent to me that much of the recent material relates to B.C., particularly Vancouver and the Kamloops area. These are the two areas I am most familiar with and have the strongest connection to in B.C. This was not completely deliberate in that while searching for materials, I did not consciously choose to look only for material relating to Vancouver and the Kamloops area. However,

by the time I put the collage together, I was aware that some of what I had chosen reflected my personal background more strongly than I had intended. Some of this was serendipitous though: I found the photos of the Kamloops Pow Wow while searching at a Vancouver Aboriginal arts store for trade beads. I recognized the photos because of the setting against the brown hills east of the city.

My bias appears in other ways as well throughout the collage that I had not intended and I am not completely happy with. The purpose of collage is to destabilize the status quo and be subversive. It is intended to shake things up. What I found after putting it all together was that I had subconsciously subverted my own attempt to be subversive by making the collage easier to read than necessary. I did not want it to be so chaotic that it would be onerous to decipher. In hindsight, I should have mixed the images from different geographic areas up more and distorted them in more imaginative ways that perhaps might have made it more difficult for the viewer but would have more accurately reflected the actual history of treaty-making. However, by the time I realized what I had done, the glue was set and there was no turning back!

In order to avoid further subverting the goal of collage to allow the viewer to create his or her own realities, I did not include a detailed list of each image, article, quote or other material used in the collage. It seemed to me that by identifying each component, I would be interfering further with the viewer developing his or her own realities in that the viewer would not necessarily discover the content through the collage itself but by looking at the list of material. This could allow the viewer to selectively view only those components that he or she deemed important as a result of preconceived

ideas of history. By forcing the viewer to access the content only through the collage itself hopefully the original intent of the collage is maintained. I have included a Works Cited section to give credit to the people whose work I have relied on to make the collage.

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Yuklaanas Native Teas-Swamp Tea (also known as Hudsons' Bay Tea, Marsh Tea, Indian Tea and Wooly Tea)

